

Provisional Ethical & Eschatological Baseline

What the Way may teach and practice now - and what remains open

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Working research for UNDECIDED

Research rule: distinguish primary witness, historical reconstruction, philosophical argument, theological interpretation, ethical safeguard, and institutional decision. Confidence may never outrun evidence.

1. Purpose

This baseline is a compact operational translation of the v0.8 and v0.9 research corpus. It is not a creed. It prevents Houses of Prayer from presenting open research questions as settled doctrine and identifies safeguards that are already strong enough for present practice.

2. Baseline register

Domain	Status	Operational baseline
Suffering and evil	Established	Do not presume suffering is deserved, divinely inflicted, karmically deserved, or evidence of weak faith; protect lament, care, treatment, and justice.
Theodicy	Open	No single theodicy is adopted. Proposed explanations must face horrendous suffering and may not be used to silence victims.
Human spiritual end	Provisional	Use healing, liberation, reconciliation, awakening, wholeness, and right relationship as comparative/working terms without declaring them metaphysically identical.
Exclusive salvation	Open	No current teaching that only Companions can be saved/liberated; no leader may claim knowledge of another person's ultimate destiny.
Afterlife	Open	No settled teaching yet on resurrection, heaven/hell, rebirth, annihilation, or postmortem consciousness.
Funerals	Established	Speak truthfully: honor the dead, support mourners, distinguish hope from certainty, and never exploit grief.
Intimate ethics	Established	Require capacity, meaningful consent, non-exploitation, honesty, safeguarding, and faithful responsibility to freely undertaken commitments and dependents.
Marriage theology	Open	Marriage/covenant blessing remains reserved pending research on sacramentality, gender/sex, divorce, remarriage, same-sex unions, celibacy, and family plurality.
Violence	Well-supported	Strong presumption toward nonviolence, peacemaking, de-escalation, and protection of vulnerable persons; absolute pacifism remains open.
Religious violence	Established	No House, minister, founder, elder, or council can authorize vigilantism, holy war, coercive enforcement, or revelatory exemption from law.

Domain	Status	Operational baseline
Rites	Established	Rites may express commitment, memory, transition, healing, and community; metaphysical efficacy must be stated only at the confidence warranted.
Commissioning	Established	Commissioning authorizes defined functions and limits; it creates no sacred caste or immunity.
Ordination	Reserved	Do not adopt until theology requires a claim beyond functional commissioning.
Sacred time	Provisional	Develop a recurring weekly/seasonal rhythm experimentally before constitutionalizing a comprehensive calendar.
Fasting	Provisional	Optional/experimental only, with broad health and conscience exemptions until a theology and safety standard are adopted.
Other religions	Established	Represent source traditions accurately; dialogue does not require erasing difference; no compelled conversion or social isolation.
Dual belonging	Open	Permitted for exploration/participation; formal doctrinal coherence varies by traditions and remains under study.

3. Non-negotiable pastoral prohibitions

- Do not tell a sufferer that abuse, illness, disability, bereavement, poverty, disaster, infertility, or mental distress proves divine punishment, karmic desert, weak faith, or spiritual inferiority.
- Do not threaten damnation, rebirth into suffering, divine abandonment, loss of salvation, or spiritual catastrophe to obtain money, sex, labor, secrecy, obedience, housing compliance, votes, or continued participation.
- Do not use marriage, family, sexuality, celibacy, fertility, or childbearing as tests of institutional loyalty.
- Do not claim that a rite, anointing, commissioning, ordination, prophecy, or spiritual gift overrides consent, law, safeguarding, fiduciary controls, or another adult's conscience.
- Do not use religious identity to isolate Companions from relatives, former Companions, other faith communities, clinicians, attorneys, scholars, or critics.

4. Hope without manufactured certainty

The Way may pray for healing, reconciliation, mercy, peace, liberation, awakening, and ultimate good. It may inherit and study resurrection, rebirth, paradise, judgment, nirvana, universal reconciliation, and other hopes. It must distinguish hope from knowledge. The pastoral need for comfort does not authorize factual claims that research has not established.

5. Confidence language for public teaching

Confidence / type	Current finding
Established	Use direct declarative teaching, while still citing grounds and allowing correction.
Well-supported	Teach as the best present conclusion, with known limitations.
Provisional	Teach as a working hypothesis/practice under review.
Permitted interpretation	May be held or explored without becoming a membership test.
Open question	Present competing views fairly; no conformity required.
Rejected as harmful/unsupported	May be discussed historically, but may not be used to govern or harm participants.

6. Review schedule

1. House-level questions and practice feedback are recorded continuously.
2. Theological baseline is reviewed annually for contradictions, new evidence, pastoral harms, and unresolved research needs.
3. Material changes require a written evidence packet, competing interpretations, rights-impact review, and recorded decision under the doctrine protocol.
4. No teaching becomes entrenched merely through repetition, founder usage, popularity, or age.

Source notes

S1 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "The Problem of Evil". Problem of evil; logical/evidential distinction; defenses and theodicies.

<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/evil/>

S2 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Theodicies". Contemporary account of theodicy and severe suffering.

<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/theodicies/>

S3 - Oxford Handbook of the Study of Religion, "Salvation". Comparative limits and usefulness of salvation as a category.

<https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/27966/chapter-abstract/211590554>

S4 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Afterlife". Philosophical possibilities for survival, resurrection, and rebirth.

<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/afterlife/>

S5 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Heaven and Hell in Christian Thought". Diversity of Christian eschatological models, including universalism.

<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/heaven-hell/>

S6 - Oxford Handbook of Theology, Sexuality, and Gender. Diversity and methodological complexity of sexuality, gender, marriage, and family theology.

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S7 - Oxford Handbook of Psychology and Spirituality, "Questions Left Unaddressed by Religious Familism". Plurality of contemporary family forms and religion/spirituality.

<https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/55818/chapter-abstract/436584599>

S8 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Pacifism". Spectrum from nonviolence to anti-war pacifism and just-war contrast.
<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/pacifism/>

S9 - Oxford Handbook of the Book of Common Prayer, "Ordination Rites, Past and Present". Ordination rites reflect varying theologies of ministry and laity.
<https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/62371/chapter-abstract/554772105>

S10 - Oxford Scholarship, Holiness and Ministry: A Biblical Theology of Ordination. Ordination as historically diverse construction of religious office.
<https://academic.oup.com/book/10994>

S11 - Oxford Handbook of the Study of Religion, "Time". Religious ritual produces recurring patterns of sacred time.
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S13 - Oxford Handbook of Early Christian Ritual, "Ritualizing Time". Festival calendars build memory, identity, and communal cohesion.
<https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/28032/chapter-abstract/211916688>

S14 - World Council of Churches, Guidelines for Dialogue and Relations with People of Other Religions. Interreligious dialogue, cooperation, and respect across conviction differences.
<https://www.oikoumene.org/resources/documents/guidelines-for-dialogue-and-relations-with-people-of-other-religions>

S15 - Qur'anic Arabic Corpus / Qur'an 2:256. Primary witness to the no-compulsion principle in Qur'anic tradition.
<https://corpus.quran.com/translation.jsp?chapter=2&verse=256>

S16 - Oxford Handbook of Religious Conversion, "Conversion and the Historic Spread of Religions". Volition and conversion in Buddhism, Christianity, and Islam.
<https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/34732/chapter-abstract/296512497>

S17 - Oxford Handbook of the Abrahamic Religions. Comparative study of Jewish, Christian, and Islamic beliefs, rituals, and interaction.
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S18 - Oxford Academic, "Islam and the Fate of Others". Diversity of Muslim views regarding salvation of non-Muslims and hell.
<https://academic.oup.com/book/5856>

S19 - Oxford Academic, "The calendar and festivals" in Judaism: A Very Short Introduction. Calendar integrates memory, worship, generosity, fasting, and natural cycles.
<https://academic.oup.com/book/62733/chapter-abstract/562692919>

S20 - Oxford Academic, "Fasting in Islam". Ramadan fasting as recurring sacred practice linked with charity and family/community.
<https://academic.oup.com/book/7401/chapter-abstract/152246227>